

an abundance of options when it comes to consumer goods, that we will never 'complete' shopping. There isn't a big boss that you have to defeat at the end, the game just goes on and on, *ad infinitum*. Hopefully, now that you understand how hedonic adaption works, you've started to think about things that you can put into place to combat that urge to keep levelling up, but this step goes deeper into why we often overspend and what we can do to change things.

You're allowed to want material things

This might seem like a contradiction to my point above, but stay with me. Materialism is a tricky line to walk, because there is absolutely no doubt in my mind that, while the pursuit of attaining an endless stream of increasingly expensive 'stuff' is futile and misery-inducing, sometimes material things can make life easier and more enjoyable. Beautiful – or at least comfortable – surroundings inspire creativity and contribute to our wellbeing, wearing bright colours can lift your mood, and I'm fairly sure that dishwashers save marriages. Material possessions can, to a degree, have a positive effect on our happiness, especially those that contribute to our safety – think back to that hierarchy of needs – and comfort, and those products and technologies that entertain us or the services that help us to safeguard our time. My point is that there is a limit to how much of this stuff we need before it starts making us actively unhappy, and that we must decide and impose that limit on ourselves in a world where there is an infinite amount